

BACKGAMMON · VARIANT 2 OF 8

Nardi

24-point board

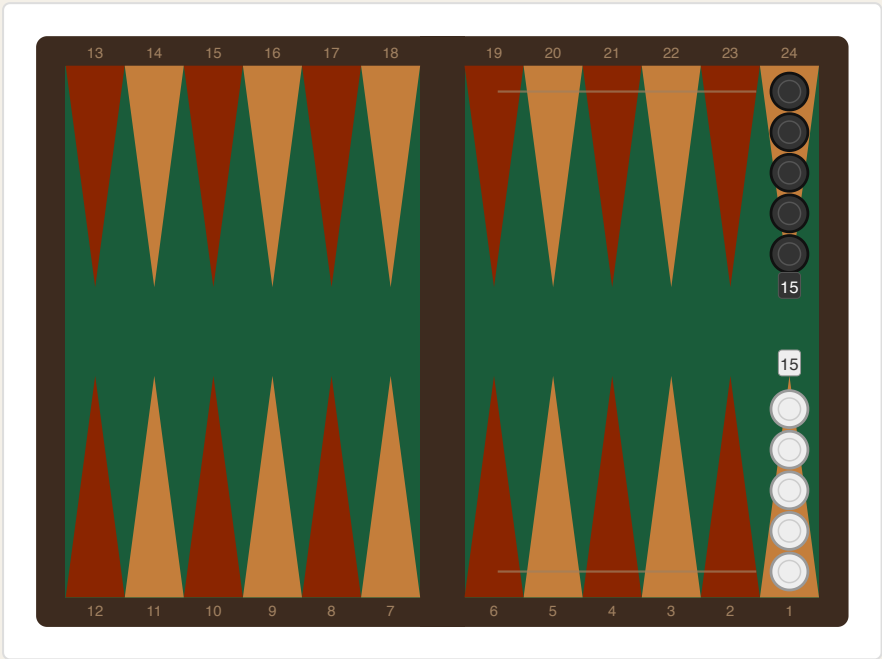
BOARD

2

PLAYERS

NARDI

The dominant Backgammon variant in Georgia, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Russia. Also called Long Nardi to distinguish it from Short Nardi (which is closer to standard Backgammon). Without hitting, the game emphasises blocking and efficient racing over tactical aggression. Widely played in cafés and parks across the Caucasus.



Nardi — starting position

ITEM	QTY	NOTES
Board	1	24-point board
Checkers	30	15 per player
Dice	4	2 per player

SETUP

Both players start with all 15 checkers on point 24 (from each player’s perspective). Checkers move in the same direction: counter-clockwise, from point 24 to point 1 for both players.

This means both players enter the board at the same point and travel in the same direction, which creates blocking opportunities but eliminates hitting.

MOVEMENT

Both players roll one die to determine first player; higher roll goes first. On each turn, roll two dice and move forward by those amounts (one checker each, or one checker twice).

Key differences from standard Backgammon:

- ♦ **No hitting:** You may never land on a point occupied by any opponent checker. A point with 1 or more opponent checkers is closed to you.
- ♦ **Blocking:** You may stack your own checkers on a point to block the opponent, but you cannot move through a blocked point.
- ♦ **Mars rule (optional):** If you bear off all 15 pieces before the opponent bears off any, you score a mars (double win).

PRIME STRATEGY

Building a contiguous block of 6 points (a prime) is the primary strategic concept. A prime traps opponent checkers behind it — they cannot advance until the prime is broken.

BEARING OFF

Once all 15 of your checkers are in your home board (points 1–6 from your perspective), bear off as in standard Backgammon. If both dice can be used, you must use both.

WINNING

First player to bear off all 15 checkers wins. No doubling cube in standard Nardi.

ATTRIBUTION

Nardi (Long Nardi). Traditional game, Caucasus and Russia. Public domain. Source: Wikipedia (CC-BY-SA).